Mary E. Witlacil

South Dakota School of Mines and Technology
Department of Humanities, Arts, and Social Sciences
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Academic Positions

South Dakota School of Mines and Technology — Rapid City, SD
Assistant Professor — 2023–Present

Colorado State University — Fort Collins, CO
Graduate Teaching Instructor — 2022–2023

Education

Colorado State University — Fort Collins, CO
Ph.D. in Political Science — 2023

Northern Arizona University — Flagstaff, AZ
M.A. in Politics and International Affairs — 2017

University of Colorado, Denver — Denver, CO
B.A. in Political Science and French — 2009

Publications

PEER-REVIEWED

3. 2026. Mary E. Witlacil. " "Political Theory Beyond Hope, Vision without Anticipation," *Democratic Theory* 13, no. 1 Special Issue: 98-113.

2. 2022. Mary E. Witlacil. "The Critical Pessimism of Theodor Adorno," *New Political Science* 44, no. 2: 248-264.

1. 2022. Frederic I. Solop, Haley N. Anderson, Christina Barsky, Emily Schnurr, Mary Witlacil. "Introducing Client-Focused Research (CFR) Projects into the Research Methods Curriculum: Key Considerations for Political Science Instructors," *Journal of Political Science Education* 18, no. 3: 284-300.

BOOK CHAPTERS, ENCYCLOPEDIA ENTRIES

2. 2026. Mary E. Witlacil "Introduction to Theories of Environmental and Climate Justice," in *Climate Justice Now! Crossing Disciplines to Combat Our Planetary Crisis*, edited by Rebecca Sophie Marwege, Nikhar Gaikwad, and Joerg Schaefer (New York: Columbia University Press).

1. Mary E. Witlacil. 2024. "Reification." in *Encyclopedia of Critical Political Science*, edited by Clyde W. Barrow, 471-473 (Cheltenham: Edward Elgar Publishing).

BOOK REVIEWS

4. Mary E. Witlacil. 2025. "Panic, the Affect for the End of Our World? Review of Ira J. Allen's *Panic Now! Tools for Humanizing* (Knoxville: Tennessee University Press, 2024)," Theory and Event.

3. Mary E. Witlacil. 2024. "Christine J. Winter, *Subjects of Intergenerational Justice: Indigenous Philosophy, the Environment and Relationships* (London: Routledge, 2021)," Environmental Politics.

2. Mary E. Witlacil. 2024. "Loren Goldman, *The Principle of Political Hope: Progress, Action, and Democracy in Modern Thought* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2023)," Contemporary Political Theory.

1. Mary E. Witlacil. 2022. "Craig M. Kauffman, and Pamela L. Martin, *The Politics of Rights of Nature: Strategies for Building a More Sustainable Future* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2021)," Global Environmental Politics 22, no. 2: 201-203.

Works in Progress

BOOK MANUSCRIPTS

Eco-Pessimism: Politics and the Anthropocene, Manuscript based on dissertation.

Pedagogy for an Imperiled Planet: Teaching Environmental Political Theory, co-edited with Peter Cannavò, Gregory Koutnik, and Mary Witlacil, in preparation (Anticipated Fall 2027).

ARTICLES AND BOOK CHAPTERS

"Techno-Optimism at the Dawn of AI: A Typology" (Revise and Resubmit)

"Critical Exchange on Hope and Progress" (Under Review)

"The Friction and Freedom of Finitude" (Preparing for submission)

"Burning Out on Hope: Climate Activism in a World on Fire" (Preparing for submission)

"Death Proof? Silicon Valley and the Denial of Death" (Preparing for submission)

"Techno-Optimism is Climate Denial" (Preparing for submission)

"From Impeding to Uplifting Environmental Justice Research in Political Science" with Jeff Feng, Michele Zamora, Kaleigh Karageorge, Inhwan Ko, and Kim Marion-Suiseeya (Preparing for submission)

"Alienation, AI, and the 'Anthropocene'" with Brendan Davidson (Draft)

"Friction-Maxing as Authoritarian Self-Delusion" with Emily Ray (Draft)

Awards and Fellowships

Best Paper in Environmental Political Theory 2024
Western Political Science Association

SoGES Sustainability Leadership Fellow 2022–2023
Colorado State University

Graduate Student Committee Supply Grant 2023
Colorado State University

Summer Research Fellowship 2022
School of Criticism and Theory, Cornell University

Best Graduate Teaching Assistant 2021-2022
Department of Political Science, Colorado State University

Graduate Fellowship, Department of Political Science 2020
Colorado State University

Grant-Funded Research

Interactive Decision Support for Sustainable Watershed Management in the White River Basin 2026-2028
Co-PI, Water Research Foundation Grant, SDSMT

Regional Resilience Center: Missouri River Basin 2024-2026
Co-PI, DOE Grant, SDSMT

AQUA-CLIME 2024-2028
Senior Personnel, NSF Grant, SDSMT

Invited Talks

"Burning out on Hope: Climate Activism in a World on Fire" June 2026
University College of Dublin: Book Workshop

"Techno-Optimism is Climate Denial"
South Dakota Mines Lunch and Learn February 2025
University of Wisconsin: Political Theory Workshop April 2025
Princeton University, CEREAL Seminar April 2025

Book Launch: Kathryn Lawson's *Ecological Ethics* Fall 2024
Meeting of the Simone Weil Society

"Teaching in Turbulent Times" Spring 2024
Environmental Political Theory Workshop, WPSA

"Introduction to Theories of Environmental and Climate Justice" Spring 2024
Climate Justice Now! Book Workshop, Columbia University

"Reflections from the Job Market" Fall 2023
Colorado State University, Brown Bag Talk

"The Case for Pessimistic Hope" Spring 2023
Northern Arizona University, Brown Bag Talk

Selected Conference Activity

PRESENTATIONS:

"Death Proof? The Necropolitics of Silicon Valley" Anticipated Fall 2026
Association for Political Theory

"Burnout: An Argument Against Hope" Fall 2026
American Political Science Association

Conference Activity Continued

"Environmental Justice in Political Theory"
Center for Environmental Justice — Spring 2026

"Death Proof? Silicon Valley and Death Denial"
Western Political Science Association — Spring 2026

"Climate Change and the Trouble with Hope"
Critical Theory Roundtable — Fall 2025

"Beyond Hope"
Western Political Science Association — Spring 2025

"Techno-Optimism is Climate Denial"
Association for Political Theory — Fall 2024
American Political Science Association — Fall 2024

"Techno-Optimism, Ecological Modernization, and Climate Denial" — Spring 2024
Western Political Science Association

"Theorizing Ecopessimism" — Spring 2023
Western Political Science Association

"The Case for Pessimistic Hope" — Fall 2023
American Political Science Association

ROUNDTABLES

"Hope Springs Eternal: So Why Is Everybody Selling It?" — Spring 2024
Western Political Science Association

"Environmental Political Theory Pedagogy: Why Political Theory?" — Fall 2024
American Political Science Association

PANELS ORGANIZED

"*Pessimism* at 20 Years" — Fall 2026
American Political Science Association

"Death, Decline, and Survival in the Anthropocene" — Spring 2026
Western Political Science Association

"Pessimism and Political Theory" — Spring 2025
Western Political Science Association

"Political Theory without the Bannister of Progress" — Fall 2024
American Political Science Association

"Misinformation and the Politics of Climate Denial" — Spring 2024
Western Political Science Association

PANELS DISCUSSED

"Democracy and Politics on a Dying Planet" — Fall 2026
American Political Science Association

"Speed and Sacrifice: Eco-managerialism and the Shrinking Earth" — Spring 2025
Western Political Science Association

"A Picture Held Us Captive" — Fall 2024
Association for Political Theory

PANELS DISCUSSED

"Democracy and Politics on a Dying Planet" Fall 2026
American Political Science Association

"Speed and Sacrifice: Eco-managerialism and the Shrinking Earth" Spring 2025
Western Political Science Association

"A Picture Held Us Captive" Fall 2024
Association for Political Theory

PANELS CHAIRED

"Information Society and Political Warfare" Spring 2026
Western Political Science Association

"The Political Theory of Crisis: Existentialism, Affective Algorithms, and Utopia" Spring 2025
Western Political Science Association

Teaching Experience

Assistant Professor South Dakota School of Mines and Technology

Science, Technology, and Society	Fall 2026
American Government	Fall 2025, Fall 2026
The Politics of Nature and Technology	Fall 2024
Introduction to International Relations	Fall 2024, Spring 2026
Environmental Law and Policy	Spring 2024, Spring 2025, Spring 2026
Political Ideologies	Fall 2023, Spring 2024, Fall 2025
American Political Issues	Fall 2023, Spring 2024, Fall 2024, Fall 2025

Instructor of Record Colorado State University

Current World Problems	Fall 2022
History of Political Thought	Summer 2020, Summer 2021

Advising

Undergraduate Capstone Committees

Colin Gholson (SD Mines) Spring 2026

PhD Committees

Arjuna Fournier da Silva (Northern Arizona University) Current
External Reader Anticipated Spring 2027

Professional Service

Treasurer Critical Political Science, APSA Fall 2025–Present
Member Conference Program Committee, APT 2025, 2026
Committee Chair Best Paper in EPT, WPSA 2025
Executive Council Environmental Politics and Theory 2021–2023
Member Charles A. McCoy Award Committee, APSA 2022
Member Best Paper in EPT, WPSA 2021

Manuscript Reviewer
Climatic Change, Democratic Theory, European Journal of Political Theory, Journal of Ethics, Polity 2023–Present
Routledge (Book Proposal), Vernon Press (Book Chapter)

Institutional Service

Member Faculty Voice Committee	2026–Present
Member Gen-Ed Curriculum Committee	2026–Present
Member Eco-SPARK Committee	2025–Present
Organizer Local Candidate and Ballot Initiative Forum	Fall 2024
Member Community Outreach and Engagement Committee	2023–Present
Member Campus Sustainability Committee	2023–Present
Co-Host and Co-Producer "Ramblin' Wreck Research Radio Podcast"	2023–Present

Additional Training

Graduate Teaching Certificate
The Institute for Learning and Teaching, Colorado State University — 2023

Cornell School of Criticism and Theory, Cornell University
"Marxism and the Problem with History" with Dr. Amy Allen — 2022

French Language Institute, Université de la Sorbonne
ISA Study Abroad Program — 2007

Professional Affiliations

WPSA: Political Theory Virtual Community	2024–Present
WPSA: Environmental Justice and Climate Justice Virtual Community	2023–Present
American Political Science Association, Member	2020–Present
Critical Political Science, Member	2020–Present
Foundations in Political Theory, Member	2020–Present
Association for Political Theory, Member	2020–Present
Environmental Political Theory Working Group, Member	2016–Present
Western Political Science Association, Member	2016–Present

Languages and Skills

English (native), French (advanced)
LaTeX